WARNING SIGNS CARD

# Cauda equina warning signs

Back pain with these signs is an emergency

**Go to an emergency department now if back pain or sciatica comes with**

- Numbness around the groin, genitals, back passage or inner thighs
- New difficulty passing urine, or not feeling when you pass urine
- Loss of bladder or bowel control
- New problems with erections or sexual sensation
- Weakness or numbness in both legs, or weakness that is getting worse

## What to say

- “I have back pain and these symptoms. I am worried about cauda equina syndrome.”
- Ask whether you need an urgent MRI scan.
- Don't wait for a clinic appointment. Early surgery gives the best chance of keeping bladder, bowel and leg function.

**Emergency: 112 · Ambulance: 108**

Based on NHS patient information on cauda equina syndrome. General information, not personal medical advice. Checked November 2026.

Insula Neurosciences